The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: Getty Images

Donald Trump announced a ten-day ceasefire between **Israel** and **Lebanon**, to begin on Thursday evening. Nawaf Salam, Lebanon's prime minister, welcomed the truce; Israel's government has not yet commented. Mr Trump wrote on social media that both sides "want to see PEACE", which he believes will happen quickly, and that he has invited the countries' leaders to the White House for talks.

Mr Trump did not mention **Hizbullah**, the Iran-backed militia that Israel is fighting in Lebanon and which is separate from the government. Nawaf Salam, Lebanon's prime minister, welcomed the truce. Binyamin Netanyahu, Israel's prime minister, confirmed he had agreed to it too, but insisted Israeli troops would remain in southern Lebanon. The ceasefire drew criticism in Israel, including from members of his Likud party.

Earlier **Pakistan's** army chief, Asim Munir, met Mohammad Bagher Ghalibaf, Iran's lead negotiator in talks with **America**, according to local media. Pakistan has said it expects to host a second round of talks between the two countries. America's secretary of war, Pete Hegseth, warned Iran that America would

“restart combat operations” with a “blockade and bombs” if no deal is reached.

Russia launched one of the deadliest waves of strikes this year on **Ukraine**, hitting Kyiv, the capital, and other cities with drones and missiles. The attacks killed at least 18 people and injured dozens. Ukrainian drones, meanwhile, struck Russia’s Black Sea port of Tuapse, killing two people and sparking a fire at oil facilities.

TSMC, the world’s largest chipmaker, reported bumper profits in the first quarter, up 58% year-on-year. Deliveries to North American customers such as Apple and Nvidia accounted for three-quarters of net revenue, which the company now expects to reach record levels in the second quarter. Insatiable demand for AI stocks has helped boost the company’s share price by a third this year.

Britain’s economy grew by 0.8% in the three months to February compared with the same period last year. But the rise—mostly attributed to the services sector—predates the recent surge in energy prices. That is expected to weigh heavily: its “gas-intensive” energy mix is partly why the IMF downgraded Britain’s growth forecast more sharply than for any other G7 country this week.

Pope Leo decried the “handful of tyrants” who spend “billions” on war during an address in Cameroon. Leo, who is currently touring Africa, has become increasingly critical of his country’s role in the Iran war. Mr Trump lashed out on social media in return, calling America’s first pontiff “terrible” at diplomacy. Meanwhile **J.D. Vance**, America’s vice-president, suggested that Leo should “stick to matters of morality”

Figure of the day: 65.8%, the share of women who voted in India’s last parliamentary election. Read about why more women than men are turning out to vote there.

Photograph: AP

The war and China’s economic recovery

China’s economy made a strong start to 2026. Exports boomed in January and February. The nine-day Spring Festival holiday helped restaurants and retailers. Consumer confidence rose to its highest point since March 2023 in February (although it remains far below pre-pandemic levels). Figures released on Thursday showed that GDP grew by 5% in the first three months of this year compared with a year earlier, faster than expected.

But the war in the Middle East creates many uncertainties. It has vindicated China’s strategy of stockpiling oil and continuing to burn coal, even as it embraces solar power and electric vehicles. It could also lift demand for those technologies overseas: EV registrations in Japan grew by 180% year on year in March, according to the country’s car-dealers association. But not even China is immune to the effects of higher fuel and feedstock prices. The war may hurt the country less than its neighbours, but it is still going to hurt.

Photograph: EPA

Limbo in the Gulf

Donald Trump is talking up the chances of more negotiations with Iran. At the failed talks last weekend, America's priority was Iran's nuclear programme. America seems willing to accept a time-bound moratorium on uranium enrichment rather than an open-ended ban. Iran would probably concede to that, although it will haggle: America demands 20 years; Iran offered five. That would not address Iran's stockpile of enriched uranium, nor whether it could build advanced centrifuges.

Iran cares about money. It wants America to lift not only "secondary" sanctions, which bar third countries from buying Iranian oil, but also "primary" ones that keep American firms out of Iran. The two sides may have to settle for a rough framework that would lift their mutual blockades in the Strait of Hormuz, see Iran pause enrichment and in exchange gain access to oil revenues frozen in foreign banks. That would fall short of a lasting peace, or the change in Iran Mr Trump wants.

Photograph: Getty Images

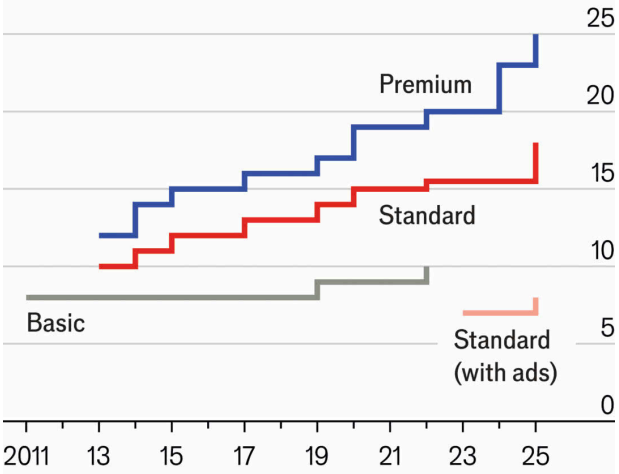
Tier today, gone tomorrow

A decade ago most Netflix subscribers were paying $10 a month. Today the streaming company, which reports first-quarter earnings on Thursday, is squeezing many of them for much more. A standard monthly subscription in America has crept up to $20; wealthier couch-potatoes can choose to pay $27 for better picture quality and multi-screen viewing. Budget-conscious viewers willing to suffer ads can opt for a $9 plan.

Netflix's market-leading position may have given it pricing power, but some European regulators are pushing back. Last year a German court upheld a ruling that the company could not increase fees without justification. This month a court in Italy found that Netflix had illegally raised prices over seven years, and ordered it to roll them back to 2015 levels and provide refunds (the firm is appealing the ruling). Spanish consumer-rights advocates have launched a similar complaint. Viewers may be persuaded to shell out, but now Netflix also needs to get judges to subscribe to its view.

Netflix and bill

Netflix, US subscription tiers, $ per month



Source: 9meters.com

Illustration: David Simonds

In for a chocolate penny

The fluctuating price of cocoa has left chocolate producers feeling bitter. It peaked at $12,000 per metric ton in 2024. Although it has since stabilised, food inflation has put off consumers. They are yet to rediscover their sweet tooth—a problem for Barry Callebaut, the world's biggest chocolate maker. The Swiss company, which processes roughly a fifth of the world's cocoa, reports earnings on Thursday.

At the end of last year, rumours circulated that Barry Callebaut might split the volatile and capital-intensive cocoa-processing unit from the more stable chocolate business, which supplies confectionery giants including Nestlé and Mondelez. But the company, which has had three CEOs in five years, seems interested in first righting the ship. In January it brought in Hein Schumacher, the former boss of Unilever, a British consumer giant, to oversee a turnaround. He implemented a cost-cutting drive, laying off staff and relocating production. Mr Schumacher will be hoping for a sweet rebound in sales.

Photograph: Getty Images

Football’s last innocent

Who are the greatest footballers of the 21st century? Two players seem beyond question: the magician Lionel Messi and Cristiano Ronaldo, an all-conquering machine. Both are now nearing the end of their long careers. But there is a third contender, too. Ronaldinho, who won the most prestigious titles with Brazil and Barcelona, had a brief prime compared with those other two giants. But he has endeared himself to football fans around the world like no other star currently playing.

A Netflix documentary series on the player begins on Thursday. “Ronaldinho: The One and Only” shows him as top-level football’s last true innocent, indifferent to the idea of becoming a global brand. Sublimely talented yet carefree, he delighted even opposing fans, who sometimes stood to applaud him. Ronaldinho represents something lost from a sport consumed by statistics and the quest for commercial success: the alliance of supreme imagination to guileless charm and pure, childlike joy.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Thursday: Which famous painting was stolen from the Louvre in 1911 and not returned until 1914?

Wednesday: Which American actress and film-maker directed the 2026 movie "The Bride!"?

Laughter is the tonic, the relief, the surcease from pain.

Charlie Chaplin